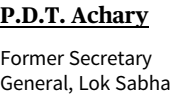




English is a de facto Indian language. It has been in use in India for at least 300 years and is the leading language of education, courts, and professions widely practised by Indians; it also serves as the preferred link language for many. English knowledge has consistently given Indians an edge in employment in global industries such as the IT sector. Indians will want English to remain one of their unique selling points as the government looks to jobs in global industries as a pathway to prosperity. The National Education Policy 2020, though advocating for two Indian languages, also mentions the importance of learning foreign languages to facilitate the global mobility of Indians seeking employment. *The Hindu's* reportage has shown that since English is the language of instruction in other subjects, it will become the only so-called foreign language students will take in CBSE schools. Many schools will stick to Sanskrit as the second Indian language all the way up to Class 10 while Hindi would be the first. Some schools, especially in the southern States, will continue with the regional language such as Tamil or Kannada as the other Indian language. The practical consequence of the current policy is removing Spanish, French and other foreign languages from schools. But any purported intent of promoting cross-regional language learning may just not be served though the Court has found merit in learning more Indian languages as a way of strengthening the federal structure. A strenuous learning of an additional Indian language serves little practical purpose though it may cater to the atavistic impulses of some. The two-language policy – English and mother tongue – would be best for India. Students can be tested on a third language of their choice through internal assessment, not through a Board examination.

A new Article was therefore introduced, providing for a central Election Commission consisting of the CEC and other Election Commissioners (EC), with the responsibility of preparing electoral rolls and conducting elections to Parliament, State legislatures and the offices of the President and the Vice-President. It is an irony that, almost 80 years later, the same

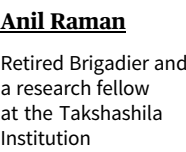


The Election Commission of India's conduct raises serious questions about legality, accountability and constitutional propriety

There is yet another category of revision in Section 21(3), which says: "Notwithstanding anything contained in sub-section (2), the Election Commission may at any time, for reasons to be recorded, direct a special revision of the electoral roll for any constituency or part of a constituency in such manner as it may think fit." The words "any constituency or a part of a constituency" make it abundantly clear that this special revision is meant to be done only in a limited number of constituencies where special circumstances exist. Thus, intensive revision and special revision are two different types of revision under different circumstances. The above

This provision could frustrate any attempt by Opposition Members of Parliament to initiate proceedings against either a judge or the CEC. Further, Section 16 of the Chief Election Commissioner and Other Election Commissioners (Appointment, Conditions of Service and Term of Office) Act, 2023, further fortifies the CEC and other ECs by providing lifelong immunity from any civil or criminal liability. It may be noted that even the President of India does not enjoy such lifelong immunity. Such is the level of protection provided to the CEC and the other ECs. It is no wonder, therefore, that the Constitution, the law and citizens appear to have become helpless before an omnipotent ECI.

China is still the main strategic concern. The National Defense Strategy aims to stop China from dominating the Indo-Pacific by focusing on deterrence, especially along the First Island Chain. Meanwhile, the Trump administration is



The evolving defence strategy of the United States offers India an opportunity to build leverage

India also has good reasons to aim for these goals. It is building partnerships with France, Europe, Japan, Australia, the Gulf, and others, while keeping important ties with Russia and

New Delhi's strategic task is to build that capability while keeping the freedom to use it. This means India needs to work more closely with Washington, but also keep building its own defence industry, technology sector, and partnerships. The next phase of India-U.S. relations will be shaped less by whether the two countries are strategic partners and more by the terms on which two increasingly capable powers cooperate.